

consignments of fruit, fish and vegetables to the industrial colony at Jamshedpur, scarcely one per cent reached their destination intact. The Mysore Chamber of Commerce states that one-half of every consignment of coal was pilfered by women who carry their spoil away openly in baskets.” This is one of many from the report that is more than a litany of complaints and crimes. It also highlighted the complex role the railway police were expected to perform. They were more than just crime fighters – they protected freight, maintained public safety, enforced racial segregation, represented the arm of the British Government in India during the freedom movement, acted as strikebreakers to control labour unrest, and played a crucial part in disease control.

Private security

Initially, railway companies had their own independent security force with policing costs kept to a bare minimum. They were only concerned with the theft of freight and railway property. Provincial police forces were in charge of actual criminal investigations. The expansion of railway lines connected people and places, opened up infinite possibilities for trade and travel, and even crime. Platforms, waiting areas, and freight sheds became hubs of criminal activity – for not just theft of property, but also the robbing of passengers, who were considered easy targets. By the early 1900s, organized gangs had emerged, working across districts and provinces, robbing travellers (see [Railway Robberies](#)). The railways also became a convenient tool for smugglers, counterfeiters, kidnappers, and even spies.

With a rise in crime numbers, the companies reassessed the role of their police. Costs were mounting and the changing dynamic of crimes called for greater cooperation between the district and railway police. By 1862, the Bengal Presidency had its own railway police followed by the North-Western Province (now Uttar Pradesh) in 1867, and Delhi and Punjab in 1868. A series of reviews took place over the next few years that sought to expand the railway police’s function. They could also be required to work outside the purview of the railways, if needed. The